ARROYO CHAMISO MICRO COMMUNITY

THE LIFE LINK



Feature Story

A Blueprint for Dignity:

The Story of Santa Fe's Arroyo Chamiso Micro Community

In April 2024, a quiet plot of land on the campus of Christ Lutheran Church transformed into something Santa Fe had never seen before. Ten crisp, white Pallet prefab shelter homes rose up along the arroyo, marking the birth of the Arroyo Chamiso Micro Community—the city's very first non-congregate transitional housing village.

It was a bold experiment in empathy and urban planning. For years, traditional congregate shelters had served as vital emergency stopgaps, but they often lacked the privacy and stability individuals needed to truly rebuild their lives. Arroyo Chamiso set out to change that by offering residents a locked door of their own, a sense of personal dignity, and a stable foundation from which to take their next steps.

Run in close partnership with local non-profit The Life Link, the micro-community was designed as more than just a place to sleep. It became a holistic ecosystem. Case managers set up offices right on-site, guiding residents through the tedious paperwork of securing vital identity documents and navigating long-term housing vouchers. Over the last two years, the village grew to include community gardens and art activities, culminating in early 2026 with the opening of a dedicated indoor community room for shared meals and programming.

Now, looking back at the village's journey, the data speaks volumes about what happens when compassion meets structure.

Over its lifespan, Arroyo Chamiso has provided sanctuary to 59 total residents. Proving that a stable environment accelerates recovery, 22 of those individuals have already successfully transitioned into permanent, independent housing. Just as remarkably, the site has completely reframed the local narrative around transitional housing. Under strict, supportive management, the community has integrated seamlessly into the surrounding neighborhood, recording zero local complaints or police incidents regarding criminal activity.

The success of Arroyo Chamiso has reverberated all the way to City Hall, fundamentally shifting how Santa Fe approaches homelessness. Inspired by its triumphs, the City Council allocated additional funding to purchase more transitional shelter units, aiming to replicate this flagship success model across the city.

While scaling the model has brought new conversations and debates about location and community transparency across Santa Fe, the original ten shelters remain a beacon of what is possible. Arroyo Chamiso proved that when you give people a safe space to breathe, a supportive community, and a key to their own front door, the path home becomes a reality.

Partner Spotlight

VITAL SPACES SANTA FE

Meet the Changemakers

Vital Spaces Santa Fe Unhoused Art is a program designed specifically to provide community, workshops, connection and supplies to artists in Santa Fe who have the lived experience of being homeless or unhoused. They share their services and support to our Micro Community twice a month and will be adding more time on site in the near future. If you are an unhoused artist seeking supplies, support or gallery opportunities, please contact Kieran, program director: kieran@vitalspaces.org.

Quick Updates

Next Field Trip: TBD

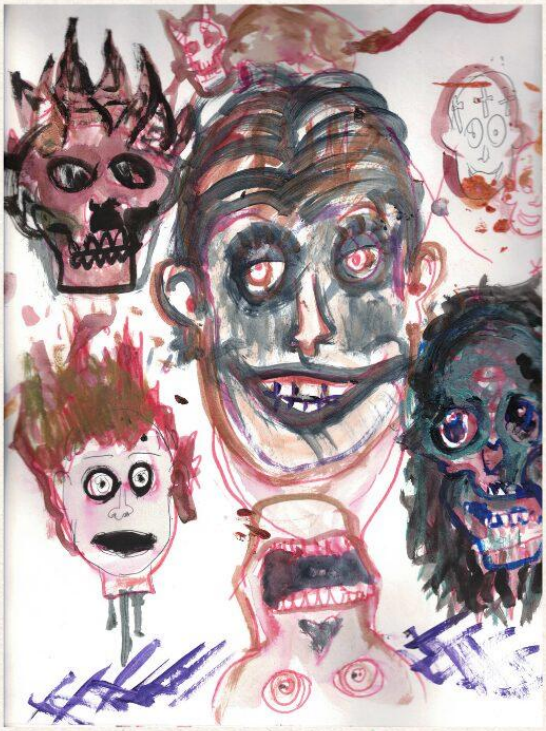
Event: Micro Community Update – Oct 21st, 6PM -ZOOM.

In the Workshop

Resident Artwork Corner

Kyle O.

Kyle is an amazing artist that works in a variety of mediums, including watercolors, ink, paint and markers.





Donations Requests:

Please only new, unopened items...

- Coffee
- Creamer
- Sugar
- Drinks
- Desserts

Stay in Touch

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"Together, small steps create big change."

instagram.com/thelifelinkoutreach

ACMC Monthly Field Trip

Regal Movie Theater Trip

A Morning at the Movies

Our September outing brought residents to the Regal Movie Theater at Santa Fe Place Mall for popcorn, snacks, and a morning at the cinema. Beyond the entertainment, theater trips offer our residents a vital sense of belonging. Settling into a row, sharing snacks, and losing yourself in a story alongside neighbors is a simple, powerful reminder that we are all part of the same community.

SF Community Yoga

Thanks to our wonderful partners at Santa Fe Community Yoga, ACMC residents enjoy weekly sessions focused on movement, mindfulness, and breathing—bringing vital relaxation and health benefits to our micro community.